The American Dream: A Broken Promise?

Can hard work still lead to success in the USA?



Can a minimum-wage job pay for the American Dream?



House

$500,000



University diploma

$100,000

Discuss: Can a minimum-wage worker afford these? What does this mean for the American Dream?

Vocabulary match

Match each word with its definition. Work alone first, then compare with a partner.

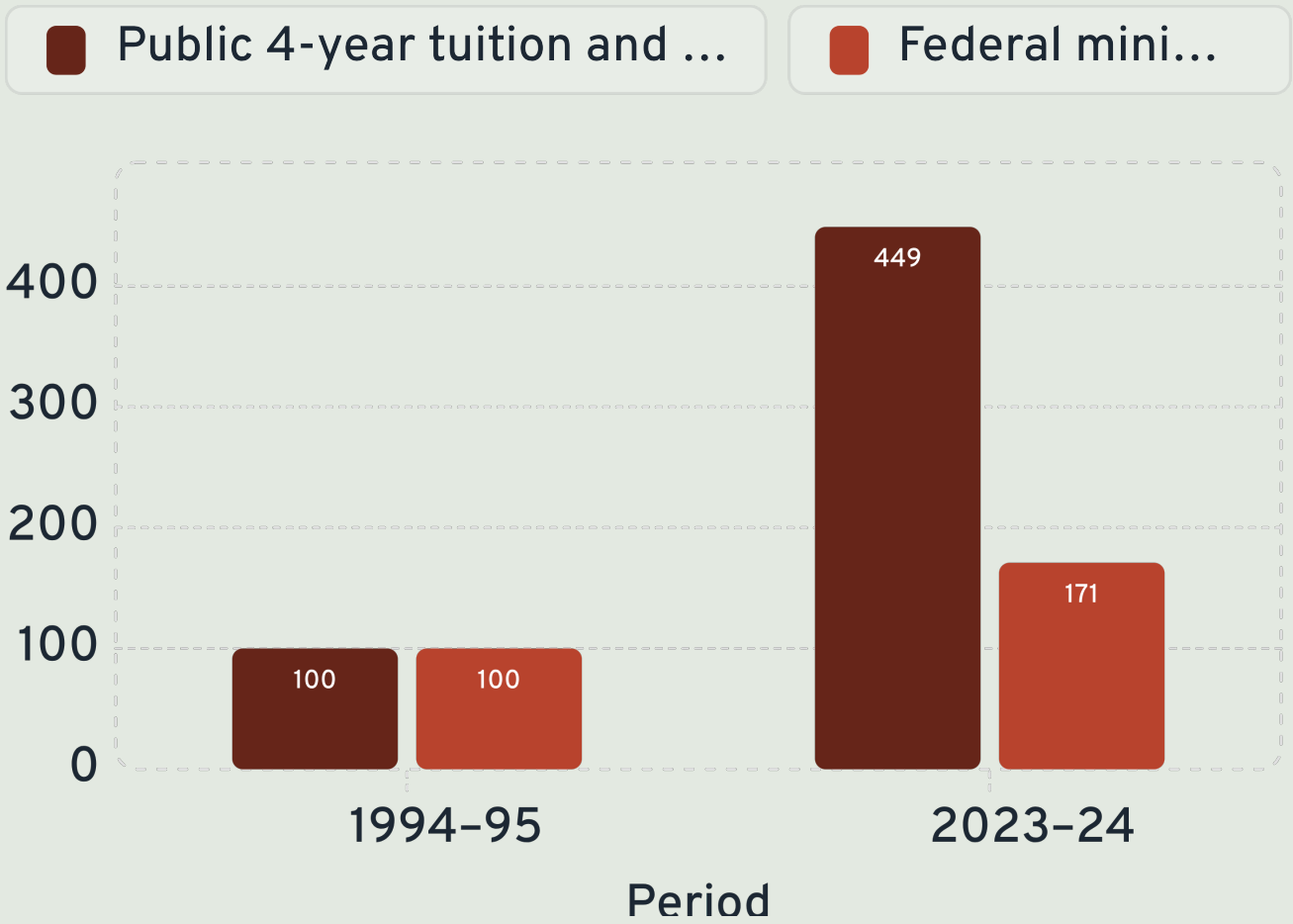
Word	Meaning
social mobility	A. The amount of money you have to pay to study at a university.
income gap	B. The difference in wealth between the richest and poorest people.
tuition fees	C. To have enough money to pay for something.
to afford	D. The ability of a person to move to a higher social class (e.g., from poor to rich).
to struggle	E. To try very hard to do something when it is difficult.

Listening: three lives, one question

Listen to three Americans talking about their lives. Complete the table with the main problem and their attitude to the American Dream.

Speaker	Main problem: student debt, rent, or…	Do they believe in the Dream?
Speaker 1		Yes / No / Not sure
Speaker 2		Yes / No / Not sure
Speaker 3		Yes / No / Not sure

The cost of college pulled away from the federal minimum wage



Tuition rose far faster than the minimum wage

Vertical axis: Index (1994–95 = 100). Values show growth relative to the 1994–95 baseline, not dollars.



Read the trend, then challenge it

01

Spot the trend

What trend do you see?

02

Compare the lines

Which line moves faster: tuition or minimum wage?

03

Make a claim

How does this data support or destroy the American Dream?

Use: income gap · tuition fees · afford · struggle · social mobility

FORMAL DEBATE

Debate motion

> “The American Dream is a myth; hard work is no longer enough to succeed in the USA.”

TEAM DREAM

The Dream is alive.

Anyone can succeed if they work hard.

TEAM REALITY

The Dream is broken.

The system is unfair: costs are high and wages are low.

Prepare for 5 minutes. Use evidence from the listening and the graph.

SPEAK WITH PRECISION

Useful phrases for a strong debate

Opinion

In my view…
I strongly believe that…

Agree

I completely agree with my opponent…
That’s a valid point.

Disagree

I see your point, but…
I’m afraid I have to disagree…

Clarify

Could you explain what you mean?
Can you give an example?